



PERFECT ROLE MODEL: Tabu with Irfan Khan in *The Namesake*

out with Forest (as in Whitaker, the Best Actor Oscar winner this year). "Premieres are fun. *The Namesake*, *The Last King of Scotland* and *Little Miss Sunshine* were all from Fox Searchlight and premiered together at the Toronto film festival. So we all got to hang out a lot. What was the name of the actor who played the grandfather in *Little Miss Sunshine* (Alan Arkin? Yes, yes). He too."

And yet Tabu is not about to pack her bags and shift to the US (although she's not averse to travelling for a day to do an interview and shoot for *Premiere*, one of the world's finest film magazines). She's also highly self-critical. "I know the work I did in *The Namesake* was predictable. I've done it before in *Astitva*," she says dismissively. "Tabu is an on-off switch," says her friend and director of *Chandni Bar* Madhur Bhandarkar. "She can be mimicking someone one minute and another minute she'll do a fantastic sobbing scene. She can give an expression even when the camera is panning," he says. Ask her about the process and she replies, with a characteristic "pah". "Every work will have its own quality. If I'm doing a film today, it will translate whatever I am feeling right now," she says.

Yet she is not cavalier about her work. Early lessons in punctuality and poise ("a heroine has to look good no matter what") taught by her guru and maker of over 100 films K. Raghavendra Rao, have remained with her. I am in agony if I am even 10 minutes late for anything," she says. She also,

sometimes, feels immobilised by the burden of expectations from a film and the dreaded questions, "so, what's next?". "Once a film is done, I'm out of it. I have to motivate myself even to go to its dubbing," she says. These days, having soaked in accolades for both *The Namesake* and *Cheeni Kum*, she is spending time keeping to her fitness regimen (she has been working with a trainer for 10 years now), reading (in the living room is a Roald Dahl book of short stories and a book on B.K.S. Iyengar's yoga), listening to script narrations, and shooting for glossy magazine covers (another process she dislikes). She has zeroed in on a film *Game On*, which she starts in June. She plays a school teacher and actor Madhavan plays the football coach.

What draws her to a film? Yes the possibility of doing something new. But also sometimes the sheer pleasure of travelling. "When I am doing a film with Sunny Deol, my favourite hero, I know he will shoot in Kulu-Manali or Switzerland, two of my favourite places on earth. And he takes care of his actors." She's known his generation of actors since the time she would accompany her elder sister, actor Farah, to shoots during her school vacation—from Anil Kapoor to Sanjay Dutt.

MANY FACES

MAACHIS, 1986:

Directed by Gulzar, she played Veerandra, in a controversial movie about terrorism in Punjab



ASTITVA, 2000:

Played Aditi Shriprakash, the wronged housewife and mother, in Mahesh Manjrekar's film



CHANDNI BAR, 2001:

As Mumtaz, the traumatised bar dancer and mother of two, she was stunning in Madhur Bhandarkar's film



Though she is related to Shabana Azmi (her mother and Shabana are first cousins), her family had little to do with acting. Her mother did not believe in chaperoning her daughter on shoots and though Tabu and she live together, she gives her enough space. Yet the two are close and Tabu says she can go to her with any "conflict". Her advice is usually the same and sensible: "*agar tumko achcha lagta hai to karo* (if you like it, do it)." It is an advice her friends also often give her—and Tabu, contrary to her intense and solitary image, clearly has an army of them. "There is a Hyderabad gang with whom I partied for a week in my new house (bare of furniture right now except a few mattresses and chairs), a Chennai gang ("who treat me like a queen sending me aromatherapy packs and tapioca chips"), a Goa gang and now a New York gang," she says. It is a sparkling mix of creative people: director Suresh Balaji, cinematographer Rajiv Menon, director Priyadarshan, "Nag" and designer Wendell Rodericks.

Like Gulzar, her father figure, they allow "me to be myself and still do interesting work," she says with a laugh. And no, they don't ask the question that everyone else does: when will she get married? "When I had boyfriends, they asked why do I have them? Now when I don't they ask why don't I?" Tabu was always a grown up girl. The industry, with its new-found respect for experience, has finally caught up with her.